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3. THE PASSIONATENESS OF BEING: THE LEGACY OF BERNARD LONERGAN, S.J.

Patrick H. Byrne

It is daunting to be asked to communicate why Bernard Lonergan is such an important thinker. The magnitude of his achievement is great, and I owe a great personal debt for all that I have learned from him. Over the course of his life, Lonergan wrote extensively and profoundly about an amazing range of topics—painting and music; economics and politics; epistemology, metaphysics, and ethics; quantum mechanics and relativity theory; statistics and evolution; sexuality and marriage; logic, ordinary language, and symbolic meaning; religion and feelings; common sense; the theory of history; sin, grace, and the theology of the Christian doctrines of Incarnation and the Divine Trinity.

Certainly Lonergan's gifts of genius enabled him to wade into so vast a range of topics and to make original and substantial contributions in each. But just as importantly, he was able to make such contributions because of what he learned about being a human being through grappling with the greatness of Thomas Aquinas, the subject of his doctoral work at the Gregorian University in Rome. He wrote of this time: "After spending years reaching up to the mind of Aquinas, I came to a two-fold conclusion. On the one hand, that reaching had changed me profoundly. On the other hand, that change was the essential benefit."¹ The changes that Lonergan underwent during his studies of Aquinas

became the core of his greatest achievements and his great contributions to philosophy and theology. The discovery about the meaning of being human provided him with a basic framework that he brought to all of his further investigations. For this reason, he invited his readers to also undertake the challenge of self-discovery and promised that they too would find it would yield rich rewards in all sorts of endeavors.

His contributions cover so many fields and are often so sophisticated that it is difficult to find of a way of communicating his achievement concisely. But one day a phrase from one of his later essays struck me—"the passionateness of being." Let me quote the entire passage where that phrase occurs:

We experience, understand, and judge to become moral: to become moral practically for our decisions affect things; to become moral interpersonally, for our decisions affect other persons; to become moral existentially, for by our decisions we constitute what we are to be.

Such vertical finality is another name for self-transcendence. By experience we attend to the other; by understanding we gradually construct our world; by judgment we discern its independence of ourselves; by deliberate and responsible freedom we move beyond merely self-regarding norms and make ourselves moral beings.

The disinterestedness of morality is fully compatible with *the passionateness of being*. For that passionateness has a dimension of its own: it underpins and accompanies and reaches beyond the subject as experientially, intelligently, rationally, morally conscious. . . . It ushers into consciousness not only the demands of unconscious vitality but also the exigencies of vertical finality."²

I take it as my task to try to understand what Lonergan meant in this passage by "the passionateness of being."

For many centuries students at Jesuit universities regarded the study of metaphysics as the most abstract, static, and incomprehensible of all their studies. There are many reasons for this reaction, but one of them originates with what was called the theory of "the three degrees of abstraction." According to that theory, there are three increasingly abstract levels of universal concepts. A universal concept is a concept that can have many instances. Roughly speaking, the first level of universal concepts would be our ordinary concepts, such as tree, car, cat, MP3

player, justice, person. For each of these abstract concepts, there are many concrete instances, and each of these instances can undergo change.

The second degree of abstraction was associated with mathematics: concepts like number, point, line, plane. This second degree is more abstract than the first. In particular, it has to do with concepts of things that don't change. A concept like the number seven contains fewer familiar qualities than a concept like cat; and unlike cats, numbers don't change. But mathematical concepts can pertain to far more individuals; just about any group of individuals can make up a group of seven, but far fewer individuals can be classified as cat.

The third degree of abstraction was called metaphysical abstraction and was concerned with being as being. Metaphysical abstraction had to do with what every being had in common with every other being. Here even the wispy qualities associated with a concept like number are stripped away to leave only the characteristic that each existing entity shares with every other existing entity.³ Well, what characteristic is that? If you don't know, then you must not have the metaphysician gene. You can begin to see why metaphysics conceived in this way got less than favorable reviews from students in Jesuit schools. And if being is what is left when you abstract everything palpable away, where is the passionateness in that?⁴

Much of modern and twentieth-century philosophy involved a ferocious reaction against this way of thinking about metaphysics. Rene Descartes complained strongly about his classes at the Jesuit school *La Fleche*. At the beginning of the twentieth century another major philosopher who had a Jesuit education, Martin Heidegger, called for a "destruction of metaphysics." Lonergan himself once quipped that one of the three most important elements of his education was the fact that the professor for his metaphysics course was appointed to an administrative post, so that the class only met once during the whole year.

This abstract, traditional conception of metaphysics was, and still is, attributed to Aristotle and Thomas Aquinas. But Lonergan's study of these two authors led him to conclude that this was not at all their understanding of metaphysics, and that this way of thinking about a third degree of metaphysical abstraction was a bad distortion of their actual thoughts.

When Aristotle wrote his great work on the philosophy of being, he himself called it *First Philosophy*.⁵ Now it bears the title, *Metaphysics*,

but that is a title supplied by some later editor. It has actually been suggested that the title was invented when Aristotle's writings were put in a collected edition well after his death. In that collection, this book came after (*meta* in Greek) the books on physics. Hence, meta-physics. That word has a spooky ring to it nowadays. But Aristotle himself called it *First Philosophy*. What he was really after was what is and should be first for us.

It turns out that each and every one of us has an implicit First Philosophy, whether we study Aristotle or not. Each of us has an implicit metaphysics. For each of us, something comes first. Our implicit First Philosophy, our sense of being, settles what seems real to us; it also settles what seems unreal to us, what is believable and what is unbelievable. Think of what people mean when they say: "that's not realistic." They are implicitly relying on some sense of what is or is not real, what is or is not being.

For some people, what comes first, what counts as real, can be what you see or touch, and everything else is just idealistic or fantastic. Samuel Johnson, the great British man of letters, had an implicit metaphysics that what is real is what you can touch. He once became quite annoyed with a brilliant Irish philosopher, Bishop George Berkeley. Berkeley had written that matter is ideal, meaning that matter is an idea that someone came up with. Dr. Johnson did not care at all for Berkeley's philosophy, and Johnson allegedly one day kicked a rock hard and said: "I refute his philosophy thus!" Johnson's primary sense of reality was that which was hard to the sense of touch. Berkeley's sense of reality was what was real to the mind but not to the aching toe.

For some people what comes first is money; this is what people mean by applying the divine attribute "the almighty buck." When money is first, when profit is the bottom line in life even more so than the ledger sheet, the reality of everything else is measured in those terms. Things become less and less real the more removed they are from money. Endangered Northern Spotted Owls or endangered urban neighborhoods are indeed quaint, but let's be realistic; they are standing in the way of opportunities for investment. Students majoring in literature or music or theology or, God forbid, philosophy, are unrealistic and impractical. When such students are asked, "What are you going to *do* with that?" They are really being asked the realistic question, "How are you going to earn money with that?"

Or, if for someone else, human suffering comes first, then the reality of everything else is measured in terms of its relevance to causing or alleviating suffering. People who have been to war zones or disaster areas witness the overwhelming reality of suffering. When they return to their homes and see what people do with their time—see people absorbed, frivolously watching television, or shopping for cosmetics—they have the overwhelming sense that these people are out of touch with reality. The sense that nothing matters as much as suffering can even affect people's judgments about art. Picasso's *Guernica* is regarded as real, but Renoir's *Girl with a Watering Can* is viewed as merely self-indulgent.

People can hold that the most real thing in the world is celebrity or tolerance or violence or love or sex or equality or fun or their children. So we all have an implicit First Philosophy, an implicit metaphysics. As you can tell, what is first in *these* senses is something that people are indeed very passionate about, in sharp contrast to the aridity of the metaphysics of abstraction.

Lonergan was very emphatic that everyone has a First Philosophy in the sense I have just been describing. Certainly, he wasn't the only twentieth-century philosopher to hold that each of us has a passionate, implicit metaphysics of this sort. But Lonergan was unique among philosophers in saying that we actually have *two* First Philosophies.⁶ We have a First Philosophy in the sense that I was describing—where something that we are familiar with and are passionate about has become our paradigm of reality. This is an implicit metaphysics that we usually inherit from someone, even when we think that we made it up all by ourselves. We usually inherit this primary sense of reality from our parents or by rebelling against our parents or from our friends or our political allies, or from the entertainment media, from our ethnic or other cultures, or from our religion. About this, Lonergan agreed with other twentieth-century philosophers.

But Lonergan was unique in saying that we have an additional First Philosophy that we are all born with, a primary sense of reality that we do not get from any other human being. According to Lonergan, there is also a sense of reality built into our questioning and inquiring spirit. We all ask questions, and our questions and inquiries are founded in a kind of "knowing" what reality is. Before we fully know what is included in reality, we *desire* to know it by asking questions. Our questioning desire orients us toward reality, toward being. Our first and most

basic sense of reality is in our desiring to know it without restriction. We are able to have a kind of anticipation about all that is by *desiring* to know about it, by asking questions about it.

As Lonergan put it, every question “supposes some notion of being.”⁷ That is to say, each question supposes the deep, anticipatory, unlimited desiring that is oriented toward being—oriented toward the totality of all that is. Our questioning, inquiring, desiring spirit forms the basis of our second, alternative First Philosophy. Unlike the other primary sense of reality that I previously described, this is not a sense of reality that is at all familiar. It is rather a mysterious sense of reality because we don’t yet know what the totality of being is. We don’t yet know everything about every thing that is. But we do have a sense about that totality because our questioning spirit keeps pointing us toward it by raising more and more questions about everything. The reality that we wonder about and that we desire to know provides us with an alternative, a strange but even more basic, paradigm of reality.

Reality in this sense is also clearly something that we are passionate about, because we *desire* to know it. Our passion for this broader sense of reality resides in our desire for it. This desire runs in and through our inquiring, questioning spirit. To be human is to be a dynamic, inquiring being. As soon as children can talk, they bombard their parents with a barrage of questions. Even as adults, each day we continue to ask hundreds of questions: What did she mean by that? How am I going to get the kids to practice on time? How can I get over this feeling? How can I make ends meet? Why is there so much violence in the world? How should I handle this new problem at work? Am I being told the truth? Questions also form the heart of the university professions of scientists, historians, and scholars. In academia, we ask: What was the cause of the breakup of the Soviet Union? Is globalization really eliminating more jobs than creating? What does economic theory say is the optimum level for the prime rate of interest? What keeps galaxies from flying apart? Questions are omnipresent and at the very heart of our quests for knowledge and understanding, in both ordinary life and in the academic pursuits of the university, whether those quests are mundane or highly sophisticated.

In all the work that he did in philosophy and theology and other areas, Lonergan built his contributions on his conviction about the great importance of our desiring, passionate quest to understand and know being. Yet we hardly notice that desire. We seldom pay attention to how

many questions we have or how influential they are in directing the things we do each day. We focus our attentions elsewhere. For Lonergan, this woeful neglect of our questioning is a symptom of the spiritual loss of our time. In a deep sense, the human spirit is the spirit of inquiry, the spirit of wonder.

But Lonergan was not content merely to draw our attention to the depth and pervasiveness of inquiry in our lives. Imagine going to a university where *all* that your professors did was to ask questions and all he or she expected back from you was more questions. If students or teachers become satisfied only with questions without any answers, something important is missing. We ask questions *in order* to find answers. Questions without answers are unfulfilled desires, and in the long run unfulfilled desire turns first to frustration and then to bitter emptiness. Some people try to pass this off as the true objective of higher education—to indoctrinate young people to question everything. But this is only a partial and therefore a distorted picture. There is a subtle dishonesty in absolving higher education of its responsibility for answers. Real education absolutely rests on our restless inquiring spirit, but it is also dedicated to arriving at the best possible answers to our questions.

So, while for Lonergan First Philosophy does indeed rest on our questioning and inquiring spirit, he also took the next step to explore how we respond to our inquiring and how we answer our questions. We don't respond to our relentless desire to know with one big answer—one big metaphysical intuition. We respond to our questioning desire incrementally, through answers to our questions one at a time. That is because our questions and our desire for being set a very high standard that our answers have to live up to. Our desiring is a grand desire to know being, but the way we actually come to know being is by answering our limited questions one after another.

There are of course many different kinds of questions and answers. But from his studies of Thomas Aquinas, Lonergan came to one of his most important discoveries: namely, that all of our questions and answers about reality are of two fundamentally different kinds. The first kind of question is what Lonergan called questions for intelligence. There are questions that typically begin with what, why, how, who, which, where, when. These are questions that are provoked by our encounters with our sense experiences: What was that noise? How did that watermark get there? Why did that structure collapse? What are those

unusual features in my data? Who am I? And so on. These questions seek innovative and creative discoveries and inventions. Lonergan called the answers to this first kind of question “insights,” and he regarded insights as the most basic and common manifestations of human intelligence.

Yet oddly we are never completely satisfied with our insights, no matter how intelligent, clever, or brilliant. Once we have an insight of our own, or when we hear about one from someone else, we raise a second kind of question—we raise critical questions. This second kind of question manifests our desire to know at an even deeper level. However intelligent or creative our insights are, we desire to know more deeply whether they are true insights, whether our insights correctly understand being, correctly understand reality, correctly understand the way things really are. We follow our insights with critical questions that seek what Lonergan called unconditioned judgments. It is through our experiences, our insights, and our judgments that we move from *desiring* to know being to *actually* knowing being, step by step.

These two different kinds of questions and answers follow upon each other in alternating sequences. We ask our questions for intelligence about our experiences. Once we have answered these questions with intelligent and often inventive insights, we ask critical questions about whether they are correct insights. When we answer our critical questions with unconditioned judgments, new questions occur to us that never would have occurred before. We experience things in a new light, and we ask all sorts of further questions, followed by still further original insights and critical judgments. By means of this cyclical pattern of questions and answers, our knowledge of reality, of being, gradually grows. Lonergan called this cyclical pattern our “self-correcting process of learning and knowing.”⁸ We respond authentically to our unrestricted, desiring spirit of inquiry not by one big metaphysical intuition, but by participating in the self-correcting cycle of knowing.

Insights and judgments are not rare things that only rare philosophers like Lonergan have. Each of us has a thousand insights into our experiences every day, and certainly we reach hundreds of unconditioned judgments every day. The difficulty is that we do not notice this. We do not pay attention to the fact that we are doing this all the time, day in and day out, in all walks of life. This lack of attention in itself would not be such a bad thing; after all, parents and health professionals and plumbers and lovers and scientists have to devote their attention to

actually answering the questions that crop up in their lives and to acting on the basis of their answers. If they directed all of their attention to the questioning and answering processes as such, they would never get their very important work done.

But there is also a great downside to this neglect. The more that we become inattentive to our questioning and answering, the more we fail to notice when we have not actually answered our own questions. We even begin to overlook many of the questions that do arise. Our unanswered questions get pushed further and further to the edge of our concerns. Instead of acting intelligently and critically, we become satisfied with just getting by. We begin to rationalize and to substitute flashy rhetoric for genuine answers. We become satisfied with pat answers rather than engaging in the often difficult and challenging work of finding creative insights and critically grounded judgments that truly do satisfy our questions.

We get passionate—Lonergan said ecstatic—about our insights. We also get passionate in our criticisms of insights when we are pursuing reality. But people are not always passionate in their criticisms and debates out of a desire to know what is really so. Instead people advance arguments with a passion about things like tolerance or suffering or money. This kind of passionateness advances some questions while ignoring and even hiding other questions. This kind of passionateness is different from our passionate desire to know what is really so.

Lonergan observed that our passionateness for being is profoundly different from the passions that underpin our other First Philosophy. Those passions often have greater intensity, but they are also very limited. Those passions can shove aside the gentler and subtler passion for wanting to really know being. But they cannot do so forever. Tolerance and suffering and money all have their place and their realities, but we can ask questions about their limits. Our questions have a mild but unflagging persistence. They can be ignored and deferred, but they cannot be eliminated. They keep coming back to nag us and unsettle us and leave us with uneasy consciences until we really and adequately answer them with creative, intelligent insights and with critical and thoughtful judgments.

There is, then, a struggle within us between our two First Philosophies. A First Philosophy, whether grounded in a passion about money or suffering or tolerance or reliance on the solidity of matter, can take over. The paradigm of reality it offers becomes first for us. And the

notion of reality that resides in our unlimited, unrestricted inquiring spirit becomes smothered and comes to seem unrealistic. Our world contracts from the rich and wondrous realm of everything about everything that we can ask about, into the narrow confines of what we find is real in a much more limited sense. And we ourselves, we also shrink. We stop becoming what we are called to be by the passionateness of being, and we become the instruments of some less grand and less noble purpose.

Lonergan saw the need for a great remedy for this shrunken horizon, and he called his remedy “self-appropriation.” By self-appropriation Lonergan meant a reawakening of our experience of ourselves as inquirers, a recognition of ourselves as people who desire and who can attain intelligent insights, who desire and who can attain limited but nonetheless unconditioned judgments. Self-appropriation means, first of all, to become much more attentive to the things that we do all the time. It also means really understanding the selves that this heightened attentiveness reveals. But at bottom, it means accepting the challenges that this new self-knowledge presents to us. Once we discover that our knowing of reality means responding intelligently, critically, faithfully to our inquiring spirit, we are posed the question: “Will I accept the challenge of this call, or will I turn away to follow some lesser First Philosophy?”

Now something interesting happens to us as we begin to take up this challenge of self-appropriation. As our self-appropriation grows, our sense of reality grows. Increasingly we become assured that reality *really is* what we pursue when we are faithful to our passionate desire to understand and judge what truly is. When we allow ourselves to be guided by our unrestricted questioning spirit, we become knowers of being, not in its totality, but nonetheless one bit at a time. There is therefore a fundamental sense in which each of us is already and always has been a latent, implicit, metaphysician. The concept of form was central to traditional metaphysics. Regarding this traditional metaphysical category, Lonergan himself once remarked, “If one wants to know just what forms are, the proper procedure is to give up metaphysics and turn to the sciences.”⁹ According to Lonergan at least, knowledge of the metaphysics of form does not require a special metaphysical intuition or even special metaphysical training. When we are authentically answering our questions, we are already implicit metaphysicians.

Still, Lonergan did recognize that there is a significant difference between having an implicit metaphysics and having an explicit metaphysics. What is the difference? This goes back to the theory of the “third degree of abstraction.” Traditional metaphysicians conceived of it as taking away from something all of its palpable qualities, every quality that could distinguish it from any other existing being. But Lonergan turned back to the writings of Thomas Aquinas himself and found that the real meaning of metaphysics and the third degree of abstraction has to do with reflective self-awareness, or in other words, with self-appropriation. Aquinas said that the third degree of abstraction is a matter of reflecting, of relating things known back to their ultimate principle, to the passionateness of being.¹⁰ Lonergan recognized that what Aquinas was getting at was that the third degree of abstraction is not an impoverishing move but an enriching one. The true metaphysician is the person who has added a second, reflective self-awareness of the passionateness of being, to their awareness of the objects in their world. The so-called third degree of abstraction is what happens in a person who engages both in the hard work of knowing something about the world and simultaneously knowing what she or he is doing while they are knowing.¹¹ The true metaphysician is the person who has therefore also developed a heightened responsibility for his or her efforts to know reality as it really is.

When it is put this way, it is clear that what Lonergan meant by self-appropriation does not fall victim to an excessive and obsessive inward gazing that would distract us from the legitimate demands on us as workers, citizens, friends, parents, and lovers. In fact, quite the opposite is the case. Self-appropriation demands of us periods of serious self-attentiveness, self-understanding, and self-criticism. But these are occasions of withdrawal for the sake of a return, as Lonergan liked to put it.¹² In that return we come back to our responsibilities to the world and to our fellow human beings with a heightened sense of our inquisitive desiring, and what it means to intelligently and critically respond to that desiring.

Self-appropriation is an expansion of our capacity for attentiveness and of the authenticity of our responsiveness. This is because our desiring, inquiring spirit is really a call. In our desire to know being we are called forth by being. We desire to know being because reality is inherently passionate. The passionateness inherent in being stirs our desire

for its passionateness. We can be passionate about being because there is something about being that attracts our passion.

This is a very different picture of the nature of reality and the nature of knowledge than the view that pictures objective knowledge as a cold, detached, bloodless affair. So perhaps it would be best to pause for a moment and dwell on an illustration of the passionateness of knowing. Since the natural sciences are widely regarded as the paradigms of genuine knowledge of reality, of objectively and dispassionately facing the cold, hard facts of reality, a good test case can be drawn from one of the greatest scientists, Albert Einstein.

Far from pursuing his scientific objectives dispassionately, Einstein pursued them with great passion. In his autobiography, he speaks of the great excitement he experienced as a boy when his uncle gave him a directional compass. He was fascinated by the way the needle “knew” how to point north without anything from the outside touching it to push it in the right direction. (By way of contrast, recall how Dr. Johnson held tangibility to be the fundamental paradigm of reality.) To Einstein this experience of the magnetic compass awakened in him a sense of its strange wondrousness. It awakened in him a desire to understand magnetism anew, and then light, and then motion, and then space and time, and then gravitation. This desire drove him to thousands of insights and judgments that issued forth in hundreds of scientific articles, lectures, and speeches. His passionate desire to understand the universe knew no bounds. Toward the end of his career, he said that he wanted to comprehend the mind of God.

Einstein detected this same desire in the best of his fellows, that extraordinary generation of physicists at the beginning of the twentieth century. He said that “the scientist . . . makes the cosmos and its construction the pivot of his emotional life.”¹³ Elsewhere he wrote that:

Feeling and longing are the motive force behind all human endeavor and human creation. . . . [We] want to experience the universe as a single significant whole. . . . [This] feeling is the deepest and strongest motive for scientific research.¹⁴

Einstein also attributes this same passionate desire to correctly understand and judge reality to earlier scientists such as Johannes Kepler, Sir Isaac Newton, and James Clerk Maxwell. I agree with Einstein that this desire to comprehend the intelligibility of the universe can be found to permeate the work of every genuine scientist.

No less than Lonergan, Einstein attributed the source of this passion for knowing to the passionateness of being itself: "The most incomprehensible thing about the world is that it is at all comprehensible." This is quite a remarkable observation. Why should our ideas inside our heads have anything to do with reality? This question has vexed some of the greatest minds in Western and non-Western philosophy. Why should our insights and judgments have any connection at all with reality? Lonergan's answer, and implicitly Einstein's as well, is that the comprehensibility, the intelligibility, the passionateness of being calls forth in us a desire for it. Our knowing is a dynamic, passionate response to our being called forth by the passionateness of being.

Whence comes the passionateness of the universe and of being that calls our spirit to transcend its narrow concerns? For Lonergan the answer is that it comes from God who breathed God's own passionateness into all of creation. Concerning God, Lonergan wrote: "Our subject has been the act of insight or understanding, and God is the unrestricted act of understanding, the eternal rapture glimpsed in every Archimedean cry of 'Eureka!'"¹⁵

That is to say, the blaze of unlimited, infinite intelligence, which is the passionate being of God, touches us in each of our insights every time we attain some limited understanding about something finite. Even if we were to correctly understand everything about the natural universe and the entire wretched and glorious history of human affairs, our desire to understand would not yet be stilled. We would still desire to know: But why is the universe that way? Why did everything have to be that way and not some other way? What purpose has been served by the fifteen billion years of the universe and the millions of years of human history? Why is there being rather than nothing? Our desire for being draws us even beyond the being of the universe to the Being that makes sense out of the universe's existence. As St. Augustine put it, "Our hearts are restless until they rest in Thee, O Lord."¹⁶

Later in his career Lonergan began to realize that our questioning desire for this unlimited passionateness of being comes to us in two forms. The first form is the passionate intelligibility breathed into the universe, which calls us forth through our inquiring and our intelligent and critical responses.¹⁷ But there is also a second, more intimate passionateness that arises directly and immediately within our consciousness. Lonergan called this second form of passionateness the religious

experience of “being in love in an unconditional fashion.” He characterized this experience as the “basic fulfillment” of our unrestricted desiring.¹⁸ In referring to this more intimate sense of the passionateness of being, Lonergan frequently quoted St. Paul’s *Letter to the Romans*, Romans 5:5: “God’s love flooding our hearts through the gift of the Holy Spirit given to us.”¹⁹ He agreed with St. Paul that this experience is not primarily a matter of our love for God. It is rather, God’s own love poured into us. It is God’s infinite and unconditional love of everything about everything and everyone. Just as God breathes the rapture of intelligibility into all of the created universe, so also the Holy Spirit breathes the passionate, unconditional, and unrestricted love that God is into the consciousness of each and every human being. We participate in the passionate love that God is, because God breathes God’s own loving self into us. This is the unconditional self-gift of God’s own passionateness into our hearts.

This of course is Christian terminology; after all, Lonergan was a Catholic priest. But he was nevertheless quite emphatic that the self-gift of God’s love is not at all limited to Christianity. Lonergan argued that this experience is transcultural.²⁰ He used to underscore this point by citing with approval the researches of the Jewish psychiatrist Abraham Maslow.²¹ Maslow interviewed people to learn more about a phenomenon that he called “peak experiences.” Initially people would say that they never had such experiences. But as Maslow would begin to tell them about his research, they would suddenly say, “Oh, I did have an experience like that one time,” and they would go on to describe the peak experience in detail.²² Based on his reading of Maslow’s research, Lonergan became convinced that most if not all people’s peak experiences were indeed instances of being in love in an unrestricted fashion, the experience that St. Paul described two millennia ago.

It isn’t that some special, select people are given this gift while others are not. Maslow was led to the conclusion that just about everyone has such experiences, but some people notice and appropriate the experience, while others do not. He further concluded that the right sort of descriptions could facilitate the process of noticing, appropriating, and living in the light of peak or religious experience. In this connection Lonergan would also refer repeatedly to the Catholic doctrine of God’s universal salvific will.²³ Lonergan read this doctrine as saying that God unconditionally bestows upon every human being an experiential participation in God’s passionate loving.

Christians rely upon the language of St. Paul and call this experience the self-gift of the Holy Spirit; but other religious traditions speak about this same transcultural experience in various other terms. The self-gift of God's passionate loving self is unconditional; it does not wait upon a prior act of faith in Christ Jesus to be bestowed. Quite the opposite, Lonergan claimed, the faith that is capable of affirming Jesus as divine is conditioned by the prior gift of the Holy Spirit. Hence Lonergan argued that all religions, non-Christians as well as Christian, grow out of this ineffable religious experience of being in love unconditionally. Just as human insights and judgments grow out of the transcultural unrestricted desire to know, so also the variety of religious expressions arise out of this unconditional gift of loving. It is the transcultural reality of this experience of being in love unconditionally that provides a basis and the hope for the inter-religious dialogue that the world needs now more than ever.

If we were to ask Lonergan himself what he regarded as his greatest contribution, I think that he would probably say that it was his book, *Method in Theology*. In a way he spent most of his life building up to that achievement. As a young man in the 1930s he was inspired by the great Catholic historian Christopher Dawson, who remarked that Thomism "has devoted comparatively little attention to the problem of history."²⁴ In his youth Lonergan set himself the task of working out a genuinely Christian philosophy of history that would surpass the works of Hegel and Marx.²⁵ Soon he came to realize that Catholic theology itself was imperiled unless it faced up to the challenges posed by modern historical studies of Scripture and the development of the Church. As Lonergan would later write: "Christianity is a religion that has been *developing* for over two millennia."²⁶ So his project in the philosophy of history expanded into providing a project of providing a new foundation for Catholic theological method that took seriously the historical, developing reality of the Christian faith and Catholicism. He originally intended his great philosophical book, *Insight*, to be part of a larger work on theological method. But he had to "round off" that book at 748 pages, as he humorously put it,²⁷ when he was called to teach at the Gregorian University in Rome. Over the next fifteen years his thought on history and theological method continued to develop until he finally published *Method in Theology*.

Does this book have anything to do with the passionateness of being? Put in extremely simple terms, Lonergan conceived of method

in theology as a heightened form of self-appropriation. Just as he revolutionized metaphysics through the self-appropriation of questioning and knowing, so also he revolutionized theology through reflective self-appropriation of the expanded sense of passionateness. This means that in order to do theology in the most effective way, the theologian must become aware of and faithful to both of the sources in us of passionateness for being: the passionate desiring to know being and the passionate love for all being.

In theological method, the reflective self-awareness of metaphysics becomes reflexive self-appropriation of what Lonergan eventually called “development from below upward.”²⁸ In the context of his book *Insight*, this meant engaging in the work of intelligent discovery and critical judgment with regard to some realm of being, while at the same time being reflectively self-aware and taking responsibility for that work. “Below upward” refers to the movement from experience through inquiry to insight and further inquiry to judgment and beyond. In the context of theology, it comes to mean self-reflective responsibility directed toward understanding and judging the sources of the Christian religious traditions—especially Scripture and the historical records of Christian practices and teachings.

But theological method is broader than metaphysics, even in Lonergan’s enriched form. In theology the reflective self-awareness of “development from below upward” is complemented by reflective self-awareness of what Lonergan called “development from above downward.”²⁹ If indeed, as Lonergan claimed, every human being is gifted with God’s love in the intimacy of her or his consciousness, this loving is still unconditional, unrestricted, and therefore ineffable. Each person is left with the immense, almost impossible task of trying to give finite expression to that ineffable gift in deeds and in words.

Still, Lonergan argued, the effects of the gift of love show up as a shift in people’s values, people’s experiences, and people’s insights and judgments. When we fall in love with another human being, our experiences of the world dazzle and sparkle. This is even more true when we fall in love in an unconditional way. The natural world, other human beings, one’s own life, pleasure, money, status, sex, poverty, power—they all take on dramatically new meanings when one is in love.

Likewise, the corrosive effects of bias, bitterness, hatred, despair, and sin begin to melt slowly when love begins to grow in a person’s heart.³⁰ When the love that one falls into is a participation in God’s

love of everything about everything, all of being becomes precious in a dramatically new way. This shift in a person's values is what Lonergan called conversion, and it begins to change what a person is willing to accept as real and true. It affects people's judgments about reality, and they seek to better understand the new realities revealed by the new eyes of love. It brings about keener attention to experiences previously ignored. This is what Lonergan meant by "the way from above downward" that flows from being in love unconditionally.

There is a general resemblance between "the way from above downward" and the form of First Philosophy mentioned toward the beginning of this essay. According to Lonergan, we all have *two* First Philosophies—one that resides in our unrestricted, inquiring desire to know being, and the other that comes from some paradigm of reality. Initially our two First Philosophies are in conflict with and contradict one another. But when the divine self-gift of unconditional love becomes paramount in a person's life, it displaces the self-limiting paradigm of reality that is that other First Philosophy. Then, the sense of being that is the unrestricted objective of the inquiring spirit, and the sense of being that is unconditionally loved come into harmony.

In *Method in Theology* Lonergan made reflective self-appropriation of the way downward also a task of theology. The theologian is now charged with two challenging tasks: the task of authentically understanding and judging Christian sources and the Christian traditions, but also the task of going forth to preach the good news of God's passionate love to all nations and to transform the world: to "Set the world aflame" as St. Ignatius of Loyola charged his followers. Of course Ignatius meant the flame of God's passionateness. Bernard Lonergan was a Jesuit faithful to the commission set down by the founder of his order. As such he devoted his entire life to discerning and appropriating the passionateness of being, and in developing methods of self-appropriation to help us all to go forth and set the world aflame. This, I believe, is the great legacy of Bernard Lonergan whose life we celebrate this centennial year of his birth.